

TEST PROCESS

When we talk of office suites, we are basically referring to the word processing, spreadsheet and presentation software that most people use. We specifically didn't take into account the database feature, since for home use or normal desktop use, databases aren't that crucial. Since we were testing only these basic components, we called in for the standard version of the software and not the professional or other editions. On the whole, we looked at aspects such as installation, components present, interface, help menu and price.

Word processors: We loaded a test text document in all the word processors and

started work on it. Specific aspects that we looked at were the formatting features, the creation of tables, provision for collaboration and revision tools, working with long documents in terms of sections, tables of content and finally the spell-check and grammar features.

Spreadsheet: For testing the spreadsheet, we created a test data that contained alphanumeric, numeric and date fields. We then worked towards formatting that data, performing simple and complex calculations, creating graphs, adding macros, and using some advanced features.

Presentations: For the presentations, we

created some slides and added a whole lot of elements to each slide, and finally checked out the slide show. Specific parameters that were tested included the wizards and templates, the kind of formatting, transitions and animations effects that were possible, and whether we could e-mail the presentation across in a compressed format.

In all these tests, we kept a lookout for features that were absent, or were unique. Also, more weightage was given to word processing abilities than the presentation and spreadsheet utilities, since obviously word processors are still the most frequently used component in an office suite.

Lotus SmartSuite Millennium Edition, comprises Word Pro, 1-2-3, Freelance Graphics, Approach and Organizer. The feature list might not be exhaustive, but Lotus still maintains its remarkable ease of use while providing most functions. Software602's 602Pro PC Suite 2000b is available free for download. This suite comes with 602Text, the word processor and 602Tab, the spreadsheet. There's no presentation software; instead there's an image-editing tool. Another free package is StarOffice, which gained popularity after it shipped its free version for the Linux platform.

The office environment

Installation, integration, ease of use (interface and help features) are aspects that you notice when you look at the office package as a whole.

Installation: Office XP and Lotus SmartSuite have similar installation features and allow you to select the individual components to be installed and also specify whether you want the component to be run from the CD. 602Pro doesn't give any installation options at all, and the only choice you have is whether you want to do a network installation (to run the software from a network server). With StarOffice, you have to necessarily install StarOffice Writer, although you can do away with the other components.

Integration: StarOffice has an integrated interface in that there are no separate icons for each component. Open StarOffice and then click on File > New to open a text document, a spreadsheet, a presentation, or choose from existing templates and let the AutoPilot (the wizard in StarOffice) guide you. StarOffice also allows you to browse your local drives, network and the Internet from the same interface. Such an interface presents an 'all at one place' approach but might look a bit cluttered if you have too many features.

Ease of use: One area where Lotus SmartSuite clearly scores is in its interface and use of

workspace. Open any document and you have the bare minimum toolbars. Exercise any option and tools relating to that option line up. Once you are done with them, the tools disappear. You can also right-click any object (say a text box, or an image) and modify all the attributes for that object from a single box. To an extent, Office XP's Task Pane option makes it simpler to use. Then again, the Task Pane does take up a bit of your workspace, so you could end up scrolling horizontally more often than you would care to.

The default toolbars of 602Pro are a bit jarring with all the icons cluttered up and with text in big fonts to explain what the icons mean. Helpful, but hardly anyone working with a word processor would need an explanation that the 'B' icon stands for 'Bold' or that '%' stands for 'Percentage'. Thankfully, you can customise the icons to make them smaller and remove the text.

Help: Context-sensitive help is what we were looking for, and that meant that if we exercise some feature or option and click on the [F1] key, we should get a help option related to the menu. StarOffice is the only one that provided such help, the rest just opened up the Help menu. In addition, StarOffice has a non-intrusive assistant that pops up automatically when you are working with certain commands. While this can be a useful aid initially, it might get irritating once you get used to it. In 602Pro, we got such context-sensitive help with the word processor, but not with the spreadsheet...the favouritism continues! Lotus prompted you to ask a question every time you wanted help—useful if you don't know what you are looking for, but time-consuming if the help you want is just related to a specific feature.



The integrated interface of StarOffice

Find it on
digit
interactive

More Info on
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